

The instant rush of love never came

8 findings · 11-step checklist · 1 myth · 5 sources · cheatgrid.com

For a parent in the first days or weeks with a new baby, holding them and quietly wondering if **something is wrong with you**, when part of the flatness might just be relief that the birth is finally over.

THE GOAL

Keep meeting your baby's ordinary needs while the feeling catches up in its own time, instead of grading yourself against an instant that was never guaranteed.

CHECKLIST

You're holding your baby, checking whether the feeling has arrived yet, and it still isn't there.

- ☐ Check what your baby needs right now (hungry, wet, cold, tired, held) and do that next, without waiting to feel ready first.
- ☐ If your baby is crying, pick them up and speak to them in a low, steady voice before anything else.
- ☐ If they're calm or asleep, hold the contact a little longer: skin against skin, or their hand around your finger.
- ☐ Make eye contact and say a few ordinary words out loud, like naming what you're doing: "let's get you changed."
- ☐ If it's been under a week since the birth, tell yourself: for most mothers, the feeling is still just arriving.
- ☐ If the thought "something is wrong with me" shows up, say instead: "**the feeling is late, not missing.**"
- ☐ If someone is with you right now, say the plain sentence: "I don't feel that rush yet."
- ☐ If you're about to compare yourself to other parents' posts online, close the app and hold your baby a little longer instead.
- ☐ Ask whoever is around to **take one task off you today**: a meal, the laundry, or watching the baby so you can rest.
- ☐ Write today's date on a note where you'll see it again, next to the words "no rush yet."
- ☐ Put your baby down, or hand them to someone, only once they're settled, not mid-cry.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1** Feeling like something is wrong with you doesn't just hurt: **self-blame** is linked to a slower-forming bond with your baby.
- 2** Don't assume missing early skin-to-skin time caused **lasting damage**: the trial evidence on this is too inconsistent to trust.
- 3** You don't need to feel it first to build it: holding your baby close **creates the feeling of closeness**.

What gets in the way, and what actually helps

KNOW

Feeling like something is wrong with you doesn't just hurt: **self-blame** is linked to a slower-forming bond with your baby.

A hard birth, feeling out of control, rigid expectations, and blaming yourself are shown to keep new mothers feeling distant. [Source 1](#)

DON'T

Don't assume missing early skin-to-skin time caused **lasting damage**: the trial evidence on this is too inconsistent to trust.

Reviewers pooling all the relevant trials found the results too mixed to prove a lasting effect on bonding. [Source 2](#)

DO

You don't need to feel it first to build it: holding your baby close **creates the feeling of closeness**.

Pediatric guidance names skin contact itself, not a feeling you're supposed to already have, as the trigger for closeness. [Source 3](#)

What's normal, and what the timeline actually looks like

KNOW

You're not alone. In one UK survey, more than one in ten mothers said bonding didn't come easily at first. Over a hundred mothers in one UK survey felt exactly what you're feeling now. [Source 4](#)

KNOW

Most mothers who go on to feel it are there within about a week. A slower start still fits the ordinary range. Some mothers take many months rather than days, so a slow week doesn't make you the outlier. [Source 1](#)

DON'T

Bonding was never a single switch. Pediatric guidance says it's **a gradual process**, not an instant. So laying eyes on your baby was never the test you were supposed to pass right then. [Source 3](#)

Why nobody warned you, and why you might not say it either

KNOW

Struggling to bond isn't something your care team singled you out for: in one UK survey of new mothers, 64% said nobody ever raised the subject of bonding with them.

Missing information about bonding during antenatal care is common, **not something that singled you out**. [Source 4](#)

KNOW

The reason parents rarely admit not feeling the rush out loud probably isn't rarity: a quiet stigma about taking longer to bond keeps people from saying so.

The people who could tell you slow bonding is common are staying quiet about it for the same reason you might. [Source 5](#)

Myths worth retiring

MYTH

If you don't get plenty of skin-to-skin time with your baby soon after birth, you've missed your only chance and the bond will never be as strong as it could have been.

ACTUALLY

This isn't right. Research on babies adopted around six months old shows a secure attachment can still form with **no early bonding at all**, so a rough start doesn't set the outcome. [Source 5](#)

Sources

1. <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC6041785/>
2. <https://www.cochranelibrary.com/cdsr/doi/10.1002/14651858.CD003519.pub4/full>
3. <https://www.healthychildren.org/English/ages-stages/baby/Pages/ways-you-can-bond-with-your-baby.aspx>
4. <https://parentinfantfoundation.org.uk/powerful-mums-survey-results-launched-to-mark-start-of-infant-mental-health-awareness-week-2023/>
5. <https://theconversation.com/bonding-with-baby-what-it-should-feel-like-and-how-long-it-may-take-133280>

Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Becoming a parent at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

[Open on cheatgrid.com](#)